Wheeler about his ideas—“Wheeler was absolutely essential in defining the problem, or rather, the whole set of problems,” he recalled—Zurek drafted a paper on decoherence in early 1981. Though Zurek hadn’t been directly aware of Zeh’s earlier work on the subject, Wheeler certainly was. After hearing about Zeh’s ideas from Wigner, Wheeler had gone to visit Zeh in Heidelberg the previous May. Soon after completing his draft, Zurek heard about Zeh’s work from Wheeler and Wigner. When Zurek’s paper on decoherence was published later that year, Zurek cited Zeh’s still-obscure work as a forerunner of his own.

Although the content of their work had strong similarities, Zurek’s approach to decoherence was very different from Zeh’s. Zeh had promoted his idea that the many-worlds interpretation was an unavoidable consequence of decoherence in his first papers on the subject. But Zurek was fairly agnostic about the interpretation of quantum physics. According to Zurek, “The whole point of [my] paper (and more broadly of my approach to decoherence) was that I could say things that were relevant to foundational questions and that followed directly from quantum theory, without any interpretational baggage attached.” And Zurek’s work was received very differently from Zeh’s—unsurprising, given the difference in their approaches and the large changes that had happened in physics in the previous decade. While Zeh had found it difficult to publish his ideas at all, Zurek’s work was published in a prominent physics journal without much trouble. And Zurek also had a powerful sponsor in Wheeler—again, unlike Zeh, whose work on decoherence had painfully ruined his relationship with his mentor, Jensen. In addition to serving as a sounding board and encouraging Zurek’s work, Wheeler helped secure invitations for Zurek to meetings on quantum foundations, which would not normally have been accessible to such a junior researcher. Zurek’s talks and ideas were received well at these conferences, which further convinced him to spend much of his professional efforts on the foundations of quantum physics. “I had been under the impression that quantum foundations was a kiss of death to a physicist’s career,” Zurek recalled. “During my student days, this was the message I had gotten from essentially everyone, with the notable exception of Wheeler. So getting invited to meetings on the basis of my foundations research was solid evidence that times were a-changin’.” Zurek published half a dozen more papers on decoherence over the next five years, as well